

still generate profits—more profits, in fact, than many other traders in the firm on the right side of the market. Describing his boss, Zachary said, “Jimmy has zero fear. If he ever has a small position, it is either because he was right on the trade right away or because the market has not yet moved against him. He has the same even emotional response whether he is up or down for the day.”

I caught Balodimas on a very good day for him—a day he had just made back more than his entire loss for the month-to-date. But had I not known he was short, I would never have guessed it from his laid-back demeanor. There was no sign of the excitement or euphoria many traders would have expressed after such a rapid favorable reversal in the markets. I am sure if I had come one trading day earlier when his equity was setting a new low for the month, Balodimas would have been equally even-keeled.

I had arrived about 25 minutes before the close, expecting to silently observe Balodimas from the sidelines. In my e-mail to him the previous day, I indicated I might arrive a bit before the close, but that, of course, I would not expect to begin the interview until after the close. I was aware that Balodimas was an active trader, and I did not want to get in the way. Immediately after I arrived, Balodimas began talking—the interview had begun before I realized it had. Balodimas made no further trades while I was there. I had assumed this absence of activity was because Balodimas had already placed all his intended trades for the day. Zachary, however, later informed that Balodimas had stopped trading simply because I was there. Not surprisingly, given the market’s largest daily decline in many months, it had been an active day. “We placed about 500 trades before you came,” Zachary said, “and if you were not there, we probably would have done a lot more. That’s just the way Jimmy is. If people are there, he will pay attention to them and not the market.” Chalk up another one for rules broken.

I interviewed Balodimas at his trading desk with his six trading screens, a sea of red quotes, as a backdrop. I found the room uncomfortably warm, but Balodimas was dressed in a heavy sweater.



You have been short this market?